

Folinic acid (leucovorin or calcium folinate)

Folinic acid is also known as calcium folinate or leucovorin. It is used to make chemotherapy work better, or to reduce its side effects.

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What is folinic acid?

Folinic acid (also called calcium folinate or leucovorin) is not a chemotherapy drug. But it may be given with the chemotherapy drugs:

- [fluorouracil \(5FU\)](#).
- [methotrexate](#).

Folinic acid is often given with 5FU to treat different cancers, for example, cancers of the colon, rectum and other parts of the digestive system. Folinic acid makes 5FU work better.

Methotrexate is used to treat different types of cancer. Folinic acid is mainly used with higher doses of methotrexate to help reduce the side effects. This is sometimes called folinic acid rescue or leucovorin rescue.

It is best to read this information with our general information about [chemotherapy](#) and the [type of cancer](#) you have.

Your cancer team will talk to you about this treatment and its possible side effects before you agree ([consent](#)) to have treatment.

More information about this treatment

This information is correct at time of publishing. But sometimes the types of cancer this treatment is used for, or treatment side effects, may change between revision dates.

You can talk to your cancer team if you want more detailed information about this treatment. Or visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) website, which has patient information leaflets (PIL) for individual drugs.

Having folinic acid

You can have folinic acid in the following ways:

- a slow injection or drip (infusion) into a vein
- as tablets to swallow
- as an injection into a muscle (intramuscular injection).

Folinic acid is usually given by a chemotherapy nurse alongside your treatment in hospital.

During your course of treatment, you will meet with someone from your cancer team, such as a:

- cancer doctor
- chemotherapy nurse or specialist nurse
- specialist pharmacist.

This is who we mean when we mention doctor, nurse or pharmacist in this information.

Before or on the day of each treatment, you will have a blood test. This is to check that it is safe for you to have the chemotherapy part of your treatment.

You will meet with a doctor, nurse or pharmacist before you have chemotherapy. They will talk to you about your blood results and ask how you have been feeling. If your blood results are okay, the pharmacy team will prepare your chemotherapy.

If you are having folinic acid into a vein, you will have it through one of the following:

- a [cannula](#) – a short, thin tube the nurse puts into a vein in the arm or hand
- a [central line](#) – a fine tube that goes under the skin of the chest and into a vein close by
- a [PICC line](#) – a fine tube that goes into a vein in the arm and up into a vein in the chest
- an [implantable port](#) (portacath) – a disc that goes under the skin on the chest or arm and into a vein in the chest.

Taking folinic acid tablets

You may also have folinic acid as a tablet. Before you leave hospital, the nurse or pharmacist will give you the tablets to take at home. It is important to take your tablets exactly as explained. This is to make sure they work as well as possible for you.

Your cancer team may also give you anti-sickness drugs and other medicines to take home. Take these exactly as they tell you to.

Contact the hospital

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will give you 24-hour contact numbers for the hospital. If you feel unwell or need advice, you can call at any time of the day or night. Save these numbers in your phone or keep them somewhere safe.

Possible side effects

Side effects from folinic acid are rare. Sometimes you may have a high temperature (fever) after the drug has been given. Your doctor may prescribe some tablets to help with this.

Any side effects you have are likely to be related to the chemotherapy drugs. We have more information about the [side effects of chemotherapy](#). You can also search for information about a chemotherapy drug or combination of drugs on our [Treatment and drugs A to Z page](#).

If you notice any side effects you think may be related to the folinic acid, talk to your doctor, nurse or pharmacist.

If you feel ill or have any severe side effects during cancer treatment, it is important to tell your doctor or nurse straight away.

Other information

Blood clot risk

Cancer and some cancer treatments can increase the risk of a [blood clot](#). Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- throbbing pain or swelling in a leg or arm
- reddening of the skin in the area – if you have black or brown skin, this can be harder to notice, but the skin might become darker
- suddenly feeling breathless or coughing.

Always call **999** if you have:

- chest pain
- difficulty breathing.

A blood clot is serious, but it can be treated with drugs called anticoagulants. These thin the blood. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information about preventing and treating blood clots.

Other medicines

Some medicines can affect how this treatment works or be harmful while you are having it. Always tell your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any drugs you are taking or planning to take, such as:

- medicines you have been prescribed
- medicines you buy in a shop, pharmacy or online
- vitamins or supplements
- [herbal drugs and complementary or homeopathic therapies](#)
- recreational drugs – for example, cannabis.

Lactose

This treatment may contain lactose. If you have a lactose allergy or intolerance, ask your doctor, nurse or pharmacist for more information.

Pregnancy

Ask your doctor or pharmacist for advice before having this medicine if you:

- are pregnant
- think you may be pregnant
- are planning to have a baby.

Breastfeeding

You are advised not to [breastfeed](#) while having this treatment, or for some time after treatment ends. This is because the drugs could be passed to the baby through breast milk.

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information.

Medical and dental treatment

If you need medical treatment for any reason other than cancer, always tell the healthcare professional that you are having cancer treatment. Give them the contact details for your cancer doctor or cancer team so they can ask for advice.

If you have appointments with a dentist, always tell them you are having cancer treatment. Talk to your cancer team before you have any dental treatment.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) to download a Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) for more detailed information. The leaflet lists all known side effects.

[Cancer Information Development team](#)

Author

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

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Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

[Get help](#)